

SELF-DETERMINED National Conference members protesting the delimitation exercise on January 1 in Srinagar

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JAMMU & KASHMIR

DELIMITATION DISTRESS

By Moazum Mohammad

On New Year's Eve, Kashmir was a picture-perfect destination with peaks and meadows draped in snow and visitors crowding tourist destinations for night-long celebrations. But as morning arrived, Srinagar's Gupkar Road—home to three former chief ministers, along with government officials and the offices of security establishments—saw chaotic scenes, with barricades and security personnel blocking vehicular traffic toward the highly secured area. The move was aimed to scuttle the joint protest scheduled for later in the day by the leaders of the PAGD (People's Alliance for Gupkar Declaration)—Farooq Abdullah, his son Omar and Mehbooba Mufti—against the 'divisive' delimitation commission draft. Then, the inevitable: the three, along with PAGD spokesperson M.Y. Tarigami, were also put under house arrest.

On December 20 last year, the delimitation commission, led by retired Supreme Court judge Ranjana Prakash Desai, held a meeting in Delhi with its associate members, including five parliamentarians from J&K's NC (National Conference) and the BJP—Farooq Abdullah, retired Justice Hasnain Masoodi, Mohammad Akbar Lone, Jitendra Singh and Jugal Kishore. At the meeting, the commission shared a draft paper with a district-wise allocation of seats developed on the basis of the 2011 census. Six new seats had been proposed for Jammu, and just one more for Kashmir. That accounted for the seven new seats announced for the state after the implementation of the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019. The total number of seats in the legislative assembly has now increased to 114—of course, 24 of those remain of purely nominal interest, pertaining as they do to Pakistan-occupied